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MODI (BELOW) MAY BECOME THE SCAPEGOAT IN THE LAND SCAM; VEDIC VILLAGE RESORT



speaking for themselves? Yes, Arabul is an MLA of the party but our leader has made it clear that he had been warned not to hobnob with the CPI(M) minister. Our leader is not taking any steps to protect him. The law should take its own turn. As for our movement, Mamata Banerjee has given a call to sit and chalk out a strategy to launch a mass-scale agitation against the CPI(M)'s land grab policy and we shall be doing so." Then, as an afterthought, he added, "But after this, do we even need to fish in these troubled waters? The CPI(M) has made matters so murky for itself that it will hardly find the ground beneath its feet if it tries to defend itself."

The exit of now-miffed giants Wipro and Infosys is many steps backward for a Government that has time and again talked of Destination Bengal for investors. That is a pipedream now. Union IT Minister A. Raja did speak to state Information Technology Minister Debesh Das and promised him a "fair review" but the IT dream, at least for now, is a closed chapter for whatever is left of Bhattacharya's Brand Bengal.

Front partner Forward Bloc, which is openly critical of the chief minister, has asked for a CBI probe into the entire question of land-grabbing at gunpoint. Says state general secretary,

Ashok Ghosh, "The problem is worse; there are no other chapters in this book to look forward to. There is no land for industry to come up, and even if there is, there will now be no investors. It's just a sad and tough wait for 2011 when the Assembly elections are due. We have to look ahead and rebuild our image which has touched its nadir now."

In 2011, Banerjee will most probably step in as chief minister to preside over the ruins of a 32-year-old promise gone awry because the creamy layer of a party, which in the first place ought not to have developed one if only as policy, just wanted to get creamier. Trinamool leader Chatterjee said, "This was bound to happen. The Government has many Gaffars on its payroll. These dons rule by the law of the gun and a Government, with only land to offer to industrialists in its image makeover plan, needs these dons. Gaffar is merely one of them. The root of the problem is the cosmetic industrialisation plan. The Government does not have the infrastructure, neither does it have a plan. It only has land which it calls its own but is actually forcibly grabbed from poor farmers. The Gaffars are mere catalysts."

The Vedic Village case, as of now involving only 44 acres of land which has allegedly been illegally acquired by the resort owners, could actually go up to a 1,500 acres which is now being investigated. The Village's owner and Managing Director Modi, who is now in jail, has told interrogators he was "too busy" with his various businesses and did not have time to go through each and every transaction. But sources say that he, in collusion with government officials, mafia dons and CPI(M) functionaries may have grabbed as much as 1,500 acres in Rajarhat alone at prices which are at least 50 times less than the market value.

Said Chatterjee, "Modi is just a front of the Government. Let an impartial probe take place and bigwigs will fall. Many other ministers and businessmen ought to come under the scanner." He was obviously referring to the likes of ministers Deb, Manab Mukherjee and Debesh Das who have held housing, and information and technology departments over the years that the Rajarhat bubble grew. Deb, in fact, as housing minister, has had a hand in land acquisitions in Singur and Nandigram. He is also seen as a master strategist on how to get land for the Government through "peaceful means". In other words, at gunpoint without a murmur of protest. ■